

ARTICLE APPEARED
ON PAGE 53FOREIGN POLICY
SPRING 1985

SILENT SPREAD

by Leonard S. Spector

Since no new country has declared itself to be a nuclear power for more than 20 years and since none is known to have detonated a first nuclear test for over a decade, it is not unreasonable to hope that the spread of nuclear weapons can yet be curbed. Indeed, if a test is taken as the standard, then proliferation has actually been tapering off. The first decade of the nuclear age, 1945-1955, saw three new entrants to the club, the United States, the Soviet Union, and Great Britain; the second saw two, France and the People's Republic of China (PRC); and the third only one, India, in 1974. Since then, no additional countries are known to have conducted nuclear tests.

This is cause for optimism, since a country that demonstrates its nuclear capability by testing intensifies the pressures on its neighbors to follow suit and further legitimates the pursuit of nuclear arms worldwide. Testing is also an essential steppingstone to H-bomb and missile-warhead development. Nonetheless, testing is but one measure of proliferation. Most specialists believe that reliable nuclear weapons can be developed without testing; indeed, the type of bomb dropped on Hiroshima had never been tested.

When measured in terms of countries that have the capability to produce nuclear weapons and that might be prepared to do so in a major conflict or in response to other regional pressures, the pace of proliferation has been considerably quicker than suggested above, and the trend less reassuring. Israel probably achieved this status between 1968 and 1973; India, in 1974; South Africa, by 1977; Pakistan is likely to join their ranks in the next year or so; and Argentina and Brazil may gain similar status by the early 1990s. Iraq was on this

road, too, until Israel destroyed the Osiraq reactor near Baghdad in 1981.

Seen in this light, proliferation has been increasing at a steady rate and will continue to do so through the end of the century. Still more disturbing, the United States, its principal industrialized partners, and the Soviet Union have shown by their actions that they will tolerate such veiled nuclearization. Provided the emerging nuclear powers keep their nuclear capabilities ambiguous, the advanced industrial countries have embraced a set of de facto restraints on their responses to such activities. In effect, rules of engagement have emerged in the nonproliferation battle. Unless these rules are substantially strengthened, they will not stop the bomb from spreading.

* * * * *

Danger at Dimona

Israel, which is not known to have tested a nuclear weapon and which has never acknowledged possessing any, is the prototype of ambiguous proliferation. Since 1962 Israel's announced policy has been that it will not be the first to "introduce" nuclear weapons into the Middle East. Nonetheless, most observers believe that Israel has possessed nuclear arms since the late 1960s or early 1970s.

During the early 1960s the United States aggressively intervened to prevent Israel from developing such weapons, insisting that it restrict the use of the Dimona research reactor, which it had obtained secretly from France under a 1957 agreement, and submit the facility to annual U.S. inspection. By 1969, however, Washington had become considerably more tolerant.

Continued

According to former CIA Deputy Director Carl Duckett, in 1968 President Lyndon Johnson was informed by the agency that Israel had nuclear weapons. The agency believed that Israel had clandestinely diverted more than 100 kilograms of highly enriched uranium—enough for perhaps six nuclear weapons—from a privately run installation in the United States. Israel also refused to ratify the NPT, opened for signature that year, which would have required placing the Dimona reactor under IAEA safeguards. In addition, in 1968 Israel was said by administration officials to have requested that F-4 fighters it sought to buy from the United States be equipped with special wiring for nuclear bombs—a clear indication of nuclear intentions. Even though some Johnson administration officials reportedly wanted to block any F-4 sales unless Israel ratified the NPT, the White House approved the transfer, one of the largest to

Israel to that date, although it withheld the nuclear hardware.

In 1969, according to Atomic Energy Commission documents, European Community nuclear officials told their American counterparts that a large, unenriched uranium shipment had been diverted while en route on the Mediterranean Sea from Antwerp, Belgium, to Genoa, Italy. Later press accounts indicated that officials on both sides of the Atlantic Ocean were convinced that the material ended up in Israel and would be used in the Dimona reactor to produce plutonium for weapons. The natural inference from this conclusion was that Israel had, or intended to construct, a reprocessing plant to extract the plutonium from the spent Dimona fuel—and therefore that Israel was apparently undertaking to develop an indigenous nuclear weapons capability. Nonetheless, in 1969 the United States suspended inspections of the Dimona reactor and increased military and economic aid.

Indeed, thereafter, the Nixon and Ford administrations declined to invoke the one sanction that would later be applied against the Israeli nuclear program: the suspension of transfers of civilian nuclear equipment. In 1974, just prior to his resignation, President Richard Nixon offered Israel and Egypt nuclear power plants without requiring that either country adhere to the NPT. This enabled Israel to continue without interference any weapons-related activities it was conducting at

Dimona, where by now many observers believed Israel had built its reprocessing plant. Later, in 1974 congressional testimony, the Ford administration strongly supported the deal even as a CIA report subsequently released was circulating within the government declaring that Israel possessed nuclear weapons. Ultimately, Congress insisted that the proposed sales to Israel and Egypt be linked to the acceptance by the two countries of international inspections of all nuclear activity. Egypt's agreement permitted a U.S.-Egyptian accord for nuclear cooperation to be signed in 1981. Israel refused and is today ineligible for U.S. nuclear transfers.

Since 1974, not only has U.S. economic and military support for Israel vastly increased, but also some of the military aircraft provided, including the F-15 and F-16, could serve as Israeli nuclear weapons delivery systems. Israel's ties with the other Western governments have also generally flourished since the late 1960s. Overall trade between Israel and the advanced free-market industrialized countries has jumped nearly fivefold. Nevertheless, the nuclear suppliers appear to have agreed with the United States to cut off nuclear trade with Israel. This cutoff constitutes the sole penalty Israel has incurred because of its apparent pursuit of nuclear weapons.

Only if Israel readied a nuclear test or, possibly, if it prepared to declare possession of nuclear arms does it appear that Israel's Western trading partners might threaten to curtail these arrangements. During its 1968-1969 arms sales negotiations with the United States, for example, Israel is said by administration sources quoted in the press to have assured senior U.S. officials that it would not conduct a nuclear demonstration. This appears to have been one of the implicit or explicit understandings on which subsequent U.S. nuclear and military relations have been based. In 1977, moreover, this threshold was written into U.S. laws prohibiting Export-Import Bank financing and American economic and military assistance for any non-nuclear-weapons state that explodes a nuclear device. For Israel, billions of dollars would be at stake.

Continued

While none of its other Western trading partners is known to have warned Israel specifically against testing, pressure from Arab oil-exporting countries and possibly the United States would certainly lead some West European governments to review their economic and military ties with Israel. And Israeli announcement of a nuclear deterrent, while possibly less inflammatory than a test, might still produce similar consequences. Any action short of these steps, however, will apparently not trigger serious military or economic sanctions.

* * * * *

EXCERPTED

LEONARD S. SPECTOR is a senior associate of the Carnegie Endowment and the author of *Nuclear Proliferation Today* (1984). As chief counsel of the Senate Energy and Nuclear Proliferation Subcommittee, he assisted in drafting the 1978 Nuclear Non-Proliferation Act.